

Chapter 02: The Proof of the Pudding: To Flourish for the Next Sixty Years

Brief Summary

This chapter tests Vaillant's famous claim that the most important thing in life is our relationships with other people. To make that claim scientific rather than sentimental, he constructs a Decathlon of Flourishing: ten measurable late-life outcomes between roughly ages sixty and eighty. He then asks which early-life variables best predicted success in that Decathlon. The chapter is one of the book's most important because it turns the vague idea of a good life into an operational measure and then compares nature, social advantage, and love.

Key Study Findings

- The Decathlon of Flourishing included occupational achievement, income, physical health, mental health, subjective enjoyment, generativity, happy marriage, close father-child relationships, and social supports.
- The constitutional variables prized by the original investigators performed poorly. Athletic body build, masculine physique, physical endurance, family longevity, and early sociability did not strongly predict late-life flourishing.
- Socioeconomic advantage was also weaker than many readers might expect. Parental social class and inherited privilege were much less predictive than relational warmth.
- The four relationship measures were the most powerful predictors. Childhood warmth, warm relationships with mother and siblings, cohesive home life, and warm adult relationships collectively predicted every Decathlon event.
- Men with better early relationships earned more, were more likely to appear in Who's Who, built stronger late-life relationships, and scored higher across the Decathlon.
- A striking military finding supports the relationship argument: attained World War II rank was predicted better by warm home atmosphere and warm mother/sibling relationships than by body build, intelligence, class, or physical stamina.
- Mature coping styles also mattered. The men with the most mature defenses reported much higher incomes and better late-life outcomes than those with immature coping styles.

Interesting Stories And Examples

- Godfrey Minot Camille is the chapter's central case. As a young man he seemed like a poor bet: unloved, hypochondriacal, socially awkward, and rated very poorly for future stability.
- Camille's transformation comes through the long search for love. Hospitalization, relationships with doctors, marriage, fatherhood, psychotherapy, religion, and connection with his children gradually help him move from self-absorbed suffering toward empathy and generativity.
- The most moving evidence is Camille's later realization that he learned love from his children. His daughter's deep affection for him becomes Vaillant's strongest proof that the change was real.

Why It Matters

This chapter supplies the book's headline result: warmth and attachment predict the good life better than physique, class, or even many early measures of personality. The finding is not anti-achievement; it shows that achievement itself often grows out of relationship capacity.